PART IV · HARMONY · 12

# Progressions everywhere

A **progression** is a trip from chord to chord. A handful of trips turn up in song after song. Learn them by their numbers and you can play them in any key.

**THE SECRET**
**Most songs take the same few trips: home, away, a pull, and home again.**

I home · vi iii home's cousins · IV ii away · V the pull back home

**The pop four**
countless pop songs and ballads

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

**The fifties**
old rock 'n' roll and doo-wop

I C → vi Am → IV F → V G

**The jazz three-step**
jazz standards (as ii7, V7, Imaj7)

ii Dm → V G → I C

**The canon**
Pachelbel's Canon and its many children

I C → V G → vi Am → iii Em → IV F → I C → IV F → V G

1. Learn the trip by **numbers**: I V vi IV.
2. Pick a key and turn the numbers into chords: in C, **C G Am F**.
3. Play it round and round. Change key: the numbers stay the same.

## Same trip, any key

| The pop four | I | V | vi | IV |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **in C** | C | G | Am | F |
| **in G** | G | D | Em | C |
| **in F** | F | C | Dm | B♭ |
| **in D** | D | A | Bm | G |

EXAMPLE

### Play the pop four in G major

I G → V D → vi Em → IV C

1. **I** is the key note: G.
2. **V** is the 5th note of the G scale: D. **vi** is the 6th: E, minor, so Em.
3. **IV** is the 4th note: C.

G, D, Em, C: **the pop four in G**. Same trip, new key.

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GAME

### Name the trip

1 C · Am · F · G

2 Dm · G · C

3 C · G · Am · F

All in C major. Turn each into numbers, then name the trip: the pop four, the fifties or the jazz three-step.

Answer: 1 the fifties (I vi IV V) · 2 the jazz three-step (ii V I) · 3 the pop four (I V vi IV).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
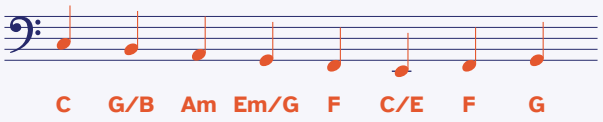



### Play C, G, Am, F, four beats each.

Go round four times without stopping, left hand plays the chord's name note (C for C, A for Am), right hand the whole snowman. Hum any tune you like over it.

YOU KNOW THIS

### Pachelbel's Canon: the trip under the tune




The famous bass walks down, and above it the chords take the **canon trip**: C G Am Em F C F G. Countless songs borrow it.

**Try it.** Play the bass slowly with your left hand and the chords in your right.

THINK OF IT A walk round the block: leave home, wander, feel the pull, and turn the corner back home.

TRAP

- × Learning songs one by one: learn the trip by numbers, then change key.
- × Mixing up the pop four and the fifties: same four chords, different order. Listen to which chord comes second.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 72 · Cadences p. 87 · Chords under a melody p. 89

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 12 · Online: Library › Chords